RCA Interview Practice — Questions

24 root-cause-analysis scenarios for Product Manager interviews

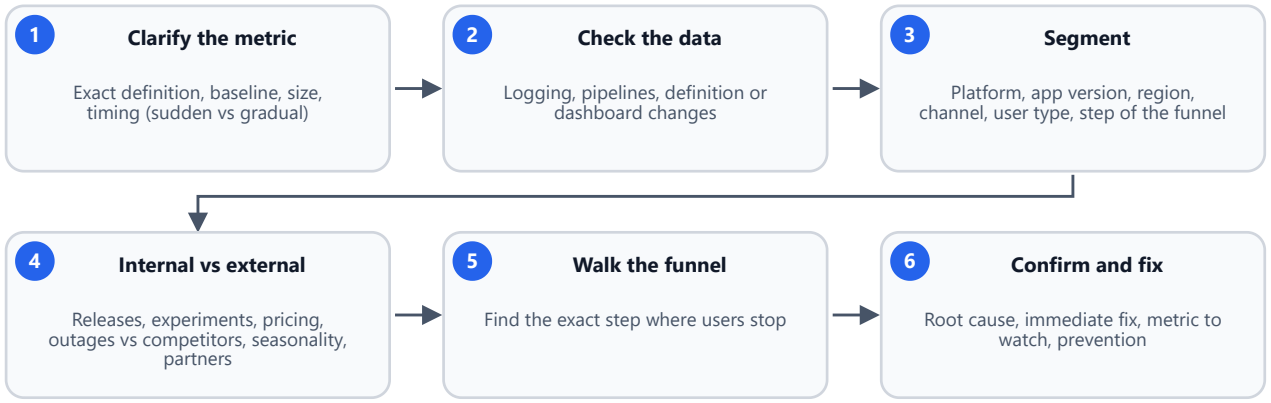
24 root-cause-analysis scenarios · Easy / Medium / Hard

12 November 2026

Independent practice material. All scenarios are hypothetical; company names only identify the type of product. Not affiliated with or endorsed by any company named.

How to use this set

Each scenario is a classic **root-cause-analysis (RCA)** interview question: a metric changed and you must find out why. Practise out loud with a partner who plays the interviewer. Your partner should use the **Solutions PDF**, which lists the facts to reveal only when you ask the right question.



A repeatable approach to metric-drop questions. Use it as a checklist, not a script: the best answers prioritise the checks most likely to explain the data first.

What interviewers look for

Skill	What good looks like
Clarifying	Pins down the metric definition, scope and timing before investigating
Structure	States a framework up front and returns to it as hypotheses are ruled out
Prioritisation	Checks the most likely and cheapest-to-verify causes first (data, recent releases, segments)
Data thinking	Asks for specific cuts: by platform, version, region, channel, funnel step
Conclusion	Names the root cause, an immediate fix, how to measure recovery and how to prevent recurrence
Communication	Summarises progress regularly; speaks with confident, statement-style delivery

Self-scoring (1–5 per row)

Clarified metric	Checked data	Segmented early	Found exact step	Fix + prevention	Clear summary

Question list

#	Scenario	Product type	Level
1	Cart additions down 15% in three days	E-commerce marketplace (Flipkart-style)	Medium
2	Food-delivery orders down 10% in one city	Food delivery (Swiggy/Zomato-style)	Medium
3	Ride cancellations up 25%	Ride-hailing (Uber/Ola-style)	Medium
4	Payment success rate fell from 95% to 91%	Payments gateway (Razorpay/Stripe-style)	Hard
5	Credit-card application completions down 20%	Card issuer (American Express-style)	Medium
6	Daily active users down 8% on a social app	Social media app	Medium
7	Streaming watch time down 12%	Video streaming (Netflix-style)	Medium
8	App store rating dropped from 4.5 to 3.9	Fintech app	Easy
9	Search-to-purchase conversion down 9%	E-commerce search	Hard
10	Revenue down while DAU is up	Freemium productivity app	Hard
11	Average order value down 7%	Quick commerce (Blinkit-style)	Medium
12	Sign-ups down 30% overnight	Consumer app	Easy
13	Support tickets doubled after a release	SaaS project-management tool	Easy
14	Checkout conversion spiked 20%	E-commerce	Medium
15	Delivery times up 6 minutes	Food delivery	Medium
16	Email open rate halved	B2C newsletter or lifecycle email	Easy
17	Seller listings down 18%	Marketplace (seller side)	Medium
18	AI assistant escalations up 40%	AI customer-support assistant (fintech)	Hard

#	Scenario	Product type	Level
19	Week-1 retention fell from 35% to 28%	Language-learning app	Medium
20	Refund requests up 3x	E-commerce fashion	Medium
21	Video upload completion down 25%	Creator platform (YouTube Shorts-style)	Medium
22	Ad click-through rate down 15%	Ads platform	Hard
23	Group creation down in a community product	Community feature (Facebook Groups-style)	Hard
24	Time-to-resolution up for B2B support	B2B SaaS support	Medium

Q1 · Cart additions down 15% in three days

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
E-commerce marketplace (Flipkart-style)	Add-to-cart events	Medium

Interviewer prompt

Cart additions on a large e-commerce marketplace have fallen about 15% over the last three days. Diagnose the problem.

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Define the metric precisely before you investigate it.
- Which surface is affected: website, iOS app or Android app?
- What shipped in the last week?

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q2 · Food-delivery orders down 10% in one city

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
Food delivery (Swiggy/Zomato-style)	Completed orders	Medium

Interviewer prompt

Completed orders in Bengaluru fell 10% this week versus last week. Other cities are flat. What happened?

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Is it demand (fewer people ordering) or supply (fewer restaurants or riders)?
- Look at the funnel: sessions, menu views, carts, payments, completions.

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q3 · Ride cancellations up 25%

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
Ride-hailing (Uber/Ola-style)	Cancellation rate	Medium

Interviewer prompt

Cancellation rate across the platform rose from 12% to 15% over two weeks. Find the cause.

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Who is cancelling: riders or drivers?
- At which moment: before match, after match, after arrival?

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q4 · Payment success rate fell from 95% to 91%

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
Payments gateway (Razorpay/Stripe-style)	Payment success rate	Hard

Interviewer prompt

Payment success rate for merchants dropped from 95% to 91% yesterday afternoon. Diagnose.

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Break the rate down by payment method, issuer bank and error code.
- Was anything deployed, or did a partner have an incident?

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q5 · Credit-card application completions down 20%

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
Card issuer (American Express-style)	Applications submitted ÷ started	Medium

Interviewer prompt

Digital credit-card application completions dropped 20% this month. Find out why.

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Which step of the application loses the most people now compared with before?
- Did the traffic mix change?

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q6 · Daily active users down 8% on a social app

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
Social media app	DAU	Medium

Interviewer prompt

DAU fell 8% over the past week. Leadership wants to know why.

Hints (use only if stuck)

- New, returning or resurrected users?
- What drives users to open the app daily?

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q7 · Streaming watch time down 12%

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
Video streaming (Netflix-style)	Hours watched per member	Medium

Interviewer prompt

Average weekly watch time per member fell 12% month over month. Diagnose.

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Is it fewer sessions, shorter sessions or fewer members watching?
- Content calendar matters.

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q8 · App store rating dropped from 4.5 to 3.9

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
Fintech app	Average store rating	Easy

Interviewer prompt

The app's rating dropped from 4.5 to 3.9 in two weeks. Why?

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Read and tag the reviews by date and app version.

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q9 · Search-to-purchase conversion down 9%

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
E-commerce search	Purchases from search ÷ searches	Hard

Interviewer prompt

Conversion from search to purchase fell 9% over a week. Diagnose.

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Did searches change, results quality, or purchase behaviour after clicking?

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q10 · Revenue down while DAU is up

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
Freemium productivity app	Monthly revenue	Hard

Interviewer prompt

DAU grew 10% this month but subscription revenue fell 5%. Explain.

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Decompose revenue: active users × payer conversion × revenue per payer.

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q11 · Average order value down 7%

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
Quick commerce (Blinkit-style)	AOV	Medium

Interviewer prompt

Average order value fell 7% this month. Investigate.

Hints (use only if stuck)

- AOV = items per order × price per item.

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q12 · Sign-ups down 30% overnight

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
Consumer app	New sign-ups	Easy

Interviewer prompt

New sign-ups fell 30% overnight. What do you check?

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Sudden overnight drops are often technical or tracking issues.

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q13 · Support tickets doubled after a release

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
SaaS project-management tool	Support tickets per 1,000 users	Easy

Interviewer prompt

Support tickets doubled in the week after a release. Diagnose.

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Tag tickets by theme and by account size.

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q14 · Checkout conversion spiked 20%

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
E-commerce	Checkout conversion	Medium

Interviewer prompt

Checkout conversion jumped 20% overnight. Celebrate or investigate?

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Good surprises need diagnosis too.

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q15 · Delivery times up 6 minutes

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
Food delivery	Average delivery time	Medium

Interviewer prompt

Average delivery time increased by six minutes this week. Why?

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Break delivery time into its stages.

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q16 · Email open rate halved

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
B2C newsletter or lifecycle email	Open rate	Easy

Interviewer prompt

Open rate on lifecycle emails fell from 40% to 20%. Diagnose.

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Opens depend on deliverability and on how opens are measured.

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q17 · Seller listings down 18%

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
Marketplace (seller side)	New listings per day	Medium

Interviewer prompt

New product listings by sellers dropped 18% in two weeks. Investigate.

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Is it fewer sellers listing, or fewer listings per seller?

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q18 · AI assistant escalations up 40%

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
AI customer-support assistant (fintech)	Escalation to human rate	Hard

Interviewer prompt

The share of AI support chats escalated to human agents rose from 25% to 35% this week. Diagnose.

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Look at intents, retrieval, model changes and knowledge-base changes.

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q19 · Week-1 retention fell from 35% to 28%

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
Language-learning app	Week-1 retention	Medium

Interviewer prompt

Week-1 retention for new users dropped from 35% to 28% over the last three cohorts. Diagnose.

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Look at activation and onboarding first.

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q20 · Refund requests up 3x

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
E-commerce fashion	Refund requests	Medium

Interviewer prompt

Refund requests tripled this week for one category. Investigate.

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Look at return reasons and sellers.

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q21 · Video upload completion down 25%

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
Creator platform (YouTube Shorts-style)	Uploads completed ÷ started	Medium

Interviewer prompt

Completed uploads from creators fell 25% over five days. Diagnose.

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Split by file size, network and device.

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q22 · Ad click-through rate down 15%

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
Ads platform	Ad CTR	Hard

Interviewer prompt

Ad CTR on the feed fell 15% while impressions rose. What happened?

Hints (use only if stuck)

- CTR = clicks ÷ impressions. Which moved?

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q23 · Group creation down in a community product

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
Community feature (Facebook Groups-style)	New active groups	Hard

Interviewer prompt

New groups created per week fell 20%. Find the cause.

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Define 'active' groups. Look at entry points to group creation.

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion:

Q24 · Time-to-resolution up for B2B support

PRODUCT	METRIC	DIFFICULTY
B2B SaaS support	Median time to resolution	Medium

Interviewer prompt

Median support ticket resolution time rose from 6 hours to 11 hours. Diagnose.

Hints (use only if stuck)

- Look at volume, complexity, staffing and routing.

Your notes — clarifying questions, hypotheses, data you'd request, conclusion: